

WI.3 Inspection Sequence

Every inspection the code names, the three clocks that let you keep working, and a log to fill in as each one passes.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Wisconsin writes one Uniform Dwelling Code that binds every new one- and two-family dwelling in the state, and then splits the *enforcement* of it three ways — a municipality that inspects with its own staff, a municipality that contracts the work out, and a town that has never taken it up, where the state's own certified agency does it instead. Your septic permit comes from the county no matter which of the three you are in. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. Your municipality or inspection agency may schedule additional visits by ordinance. The list below is the state minimum that applies everywhere.

THE THREE CLOCKS

These are the most valuable numbers in this document, and most owner-builders never learn them. Wisconsin does not leave you waiting indefinitely for an inspector. It gives you a release in every direction — one to keep building, one to move in, and one on the septic.

All three releases, in the code's own words

To keep building — two business days. The general rule is that *“construction may not proceed beyond the point of inspection until the inspection has been completed”*. But: **“Construction may proceed if the inspection has not taken place by the end of the second business day following the day of notification or as otherwise agreed between the applicant and the municipality or authorized UDC inspection agency.”** (s. SPS 320.10(2)(b)2. and 3.)

To move in — five business days. *“the dwelling may not be occupied until a final inspection has been made that finds no critical violations of this code that could reasonably be expected to affect the health or safety of a person using the dwelling.”* But: **“Occupancy may proceed in accordance with local ordinances if the inspection has not been completed by the end of the fifth business day following the day of notification or as otherwise agreed between the applicant and the department or municipality.”** (s. SPS 320.10(3)(h)1. and 2.)

And for the septic — the next workday. *“If an inspection is not made by the end of the next workday, excluding Saturdays, Sundays and holidays, after the requested inspection day, the master plumber or the master plumber-restricted service may proceed with the installation of the POWTS, including backfilling and covering.”* (s. SPS 383.26(2)(e))

How to actually use these. Each clock runs from the day you gave *notification*, so the notification is the thing to document. Request in writing or by a method that leaves a record, note the date and time on the log at the back of this document, and photograph the work before you cover it. A clock you cannot prove you started is a clock you do not have.

WHO INSPECTS, AND WHY YOU CANNOT SHOP

Every inspection “*shall be performed by an inspector certified in accordance with ch. SPS 305 who holds the respective credential for the inspection performed*” (s. SPS 320.10(1)). One person may hold several credentials, which is why a single inspector often covers construction, electrical, plumbing and HVAC on a rural job — but each credential is separate and each must be held.

If you are in a municipality where the department has jurisdiction, remember the lock-in from WI.1: “*A person who obtains a Wisconsin uniform building permit from a registered UDC inspection agency shall retain the same agency to conduct the inspections for the project*” (s. SPS 320.08(2)). Choose the agency before you file, not after your first disagreement.

THE INSPECTIONS, IN ORDER

Section SPS 320.10(3) names eight inspection types. Here they are in build order, with what the code actually says about each.

Wis. Admin. Code s. SPS 320.10(3)(b) to (i)

Inspection	What the code requires
Erosion control	Performed “ <i>concurrently with all other required construction inspections</i> ”, and the delegated authority may add more. So it is not one visit — your control measures have to be right every time somebody comes out
Foundation excavation	“ <i>after the placement of any forms or required reinforcement and prior to the placement of the permanent foundation material</i> ”. If drain tile is required — by the inspector or by groundwater in the hole — “ <i>the presence and location of bleeders used to connect the interior and exterior drain tile</i> ” is inspected at the same time
Foundation reinforcement	“ <i>The placement of reinforcement shall be inspected where the reinforcement is required for code compliance</i> ”
Foundation	“ <i>after completion</i> ” — and where dampproofing, exterior insulation or drain tile are required, before backfilling . Do not backfill on a promise
Rough — five categories	“ <i>after the rough work is constructed but before it is concealed</i> ”, for: a. the basement floor area; b. general construction, including framing; c. rough electrical; d. rough plumbing; e. rough heating, ventilating and air conditioning
Insulation	“ <i>of the insulation and vapor retarders after they are installed but before they are concealed</i> ” — so this is before drywall, and it covers the vapor retarder too

Wis. Admin. Code s. SPS 320.10(3)(b) to (i)

Inspection	What the code requires
Final	The occupancy gate. See the five-business-day release above
Installation	Only if you are setting a manufactured or modular home

You choose how the rough inspections are packaged

"All categories of work for rough inspections may be completed before the notice for inspection is given, provided the work has not been covered." and "The applicant may request one rough inspection or individual rough inspections." (s. SPS 320.10(3)(f)2. and 3.)

That is a real scheduling decision. One combined rough means one visit and usually one fee — the code allows *"a separate fee ... for each individual inspection"* (subd. 4.) — but it also means every trade has to be finished and correct on the same day, and one failure can hold up the others. Individual roughs cost more and let each trade clear on its own schedule. On a self-performed build where you are doing the work in sequence anyway, individual roughs are usually the calmer choice.

THE SEPTIC INSPECTION IS A SEPARATE TRACK

Your POWTS is inspected by the county under a different chapter, by a certified POWTS inspector, and it is the master plumber — not you — who calls it in. *"The master plumber or the master plumber-restricted service responsible for the installation of a POWTS ... shall notify the governmental unit when the work will be or is ready for inspection" and "shall provide the necessary equipment and properly licensed personnel required for the inspection"* (s. SPS 383.26(2)(b) and (d)).

The rule against covering work is stricter here than on the building side: *"no part of a POWTS component may be covered nor any POWTS component put into service until the governmental unit or the department has had an opportunity to inspect the system"* (s. SPS 383.26(2)(a)) — with the next-workday release quoted earlier.

Weather can stop the septic install outright

Three conditions in s. SPS 383.45 will send the crew home, and they matter for scheduling a Wisconsin build season:

Frozen soil. Components consisting in part of in situ soil *"may not be installed if the soil is frozen at or below the infiltrative surface of the component"*. **Snow.** *"Snow cover shall be removed before excavating or installing."* **Moisture.** *"If the soil at the infiltrative surface can be rolled into a ¼-inch wire, the installation may not proceed."*

The wire test is the one that surprises people — it is a wet-soil test, not a cold one, and it can stop work in a rainy June as easily as a frozen November.

HOW RESULTS ARE COMMUNICATED

“Notice of compliance or noncompliance with this code shall be written on the building permit or another readily visible means and posted at the job site”, or delivered electronically if you and the inspector both agree (s. SPS 320.10(4)(a)1.). On a finding of noncompliance the authority “shall also notify the applicant of record and the owner, in writing, of the violations to be corrected” (subd. 2.). As an owner-builder you are both, so you should receive it twice over — and if you get a verbal correction only, ask for it in writing.

One protection worth knowing at the end of the job: your municipality may not invent occupancy conditions. *“A municipality may not adopt an ordinance on any subject falling within the scope of this code including establishing restrictions on the occupancy of dwellings for any reason other than noncompliance with the provisions of this code” (s. SPS 320.02(2)(a)).*

Occupancy turns on the final inspection finding no critical code violations — not on landscaping, not on a driveway being paved, not on a final grade certificate, unless some other body of law requires it.

INSPECTION LOG

Record the date you gave notification as well as the date of the visit. The notification date is what starts the two-business-day and five-business-day clocks, and it is the only one you control.

Building inspections — s. SPS 320.10(3)

	Item	Date	Inspector
☐	Foundation excavation (and bleeders, if drain tile required) Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Foundation reinforcement Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Foundation — before backfill Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Rough — basement floor area Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Rough — general construction and framing Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Rough — electrical Notified _____ Result _____		

Building inspections — s. SPS 320.10(3)

	Item	Date	Inspector
☐	Rough — plumbing Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Rough — heating, ventilating and air conditioning Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Insulation and vapor retarders — before concealment Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Final — the occupancy gate Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Installation (manufactured or modular home only) Notified _____ Result _____		

Septic and water — the county and DNR track

	Item	Date	Office
☐	POWTS inspection before any component is covered Notified _____ Result _____		
☐	Well construction report filed by the driller Driller _____ Date _____		
☐	Coliform and nitrate samples collected Date _____ Result _____		

Sources — every Wisconsin claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Certified inspector holding the credential for that inspection	s. SPS 320.10(1)
Applicant requests; no work past the point of inspection	s. SPS 320.10(2)(b)1., 2.
Two business days, then construction may proceed	s. SPS 320.10(2)(b)3.
The eight inspection types and what each covers	s. SPS 320.10(3)(b) to (i)
One rough inspection or individual roughs, applicant's choice	s. SPS 320.10(3)(f)2., 3.

Sources — every Wisconsin claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
No occupancy before a final finding no critical violations	s. SPS 320.10(3)(h)1.
Five business days, then occupancy may proceed	s. SPS 320.10(3)(h)2.
Notice posted at the job site; written notice of violations	s. SPS 320.10(4)(a)1., 2.
Occupancy may not be restricted for non-code reasons	s. SPS 320.02(2)(a)
Locked to the agency that issued the permit	s. SPS 320.08(2)
No POWTS component covered before inspection; next-workday release	s. SPS 383.26(2)(a), (e)
The master plumber calls in the POWTS inspection	s. SPS 383.26(2)(b), (d)
Frozen soil, snow cover and the quarter-inch wire test	s. SPS 383.45(2), (3), (4)

Everything cited in this kit is free to read at **docs.legis.wisconsin.gov**, and the site takes a citation directly as a URL. For a statute — a **Wis. Stat.** section such as 101.65 — open **docs.legis.wisconsin.gov/statutes/statutes/101** and find the section in the chapter. For a rule — a **Wis. Admin. Code** chapter such as SPS 321 or NR 812 — open **docs.legis.wisconsin.gov/code/admin_code** and pick the agency: **SPS** is Safety and Professional Services, which writes the Uniform Dwelling Code and the septic code, and **NR** is Natural Resources, which writes the well code and shoreland zoning. **One habit worth keeping when you check a number:** every chapter page prints its register date at the foot, in the form “Register month year No. nnn”. That date, not the year in the chapter title, tells you how current the text on your screen is. All text here was read at that source, September 2026.